

Building Bridges

By Adam Kershner

“We should probably stand back,” said Catherine as the dump truck pulled up to the work shed. Mud splattered against the truck’s sides as its tires dug in for traction. A cloud of black smoke coughed and sputtered from the exhaust pipe, stinging my nostrils with petroleum. In the front seat, the driver gave a thumbs-up to the Rwandan construction workers standing beside me. Yellow lights flashed and warning sirens sounded. Creaking and groaning, a massive jack extended the load high into the air, as the bed of the truck tilted to almost ninety degrees. At first, pebbles and fragmented chips snuck through the cracks, and then the whole load came thundering down. Slabs of rock toppled out the back of the truck and rolled into a dusty pile. Kicking up more dust, the truck rumbled away over the hills.

Down at the foundation trenches, Rwandan construction workers laid down their hoes and shovels, hiked up to the drop-off site, and began lifting the rocks onto each other’s heads and shoulders immediately. I recognized Jamvier from his frayed sweater and wool beanie that covered his forehead. He was the strongest construction worker at the site, hoisting jagged boulders the size of mini-fridges onto his bare shoulder blades without breaking a sweat. Sometimes he carried the enormous rocks on his head without using his hands, strolling nonchalantly from the drop-off site to the bridge site and back again without complaint.

Since the road was too narrow and bumpy for the delivery truck to pull up to the worksite, it dropped its load roughly two hundred meters away near the equipment shed.

There was no easy solution to widen the road or transport the rocks. “I’ll call Bridges to Prosperity and ask Etienne if we can have more wheelbarrows, but honestly, it looks like we’re just going to have to suck it up and carry these rocks by hand,” said Connor, our team leader. Growing up on the shores of Miami, Connor brought his cool-headed surfer mentality to leading the team. Slipping on my work gloves, I chose a suitable rock and got to work.

As members of Duke Engineers for International Development, our task was to build a bridge in the northern province of Rwanda, connecting the Rwamahwa and Cyohoha communities. During the rainy season, the Nyabugogo river floods on a weekly basis, often destroying the unstable log bridge the villagers used to cross. Over the decades, many elderly and children drowned in the fast current after falling accidentally. Every Sunday of my freshman year, I met with the rest of the travel team in Hudson Computer Lab 226 to design our bridge on AutoCAD. The ten of us pored over the surveys and pictures sent by Etienne, our Bridges to Prosperity contact in Rwanda. Clustering around the computers, we crunched numbers on sheets of graph paper, scrawled diagrams on the whiteboards, scrutinized angles and lengths to the nearest millimeter, and ultimately decided to build a three-tier suspended footbridge. We calculated the amounts of raw materials needed to build our design, consolidated our statistics, diagrams, and spreadsheets into a PowerPoint presentation, and sent our plans to professional civil engineers at Bridges to Prosperity for approval. Even though we wouldn’t set foot in Rwanda for another six months, we wanted to learn as much as possible about its history and politics; so, we watched the documentary “Coexist.”

Focusing on post-Genocide politics and society, the documentary details Rwanda's development and progress after 1 million were slaughtered in 100 days. Even after two decades, with killers and survivors forced to live as neighbors, the scars of the Genocide are far from healing.

Even as I boarded my flight, I didn't know what to expect. I had packed five different anti-mosquito sprays with varying percentages of DEET, sun-protective outerwear, packages of beef jerky, a ridiculous quantity of Nyquil, eight packs of full-body shower wipes, and a Kinyarwanda-English dictionary, which I planned to begin reading one hour into the flight. I had spoken to my friend Lily about traveling to Africa, and she told me, "No matter how well-prepared you are, you won't be prepared."

Located in the Northern Province, Rulindo District, Base Sector, and Rwamahwa Cell, the mountain village of Kiruli is rural and isolated, with dusty motorcycle paths winding around the tea fields that connect it to the surrounding villages of Nyirangarama and Machine. While small bars and bakeries have sprung up recently, only ten years ago Kiruli was without electricity - the little village had come a long way. When the team entered Kiruli for the first time, men dropped their wrenches and stopped fixing their bicycles. Women held their babies close and watched from a distance. The elderly, sensing the disturbance, emerged from the bakeries and bars to see what all the commotion was about. Children swarmed our van, grabbing and climbing on the back bumper, smooshing their faces against the glass windows. When they saw us, they screamed at the top of their lungs "*Abazungu!*" – *white man*. While I unpacked my luggage from the trunk, villagers crowded around, staring directly at me like I was a six-

eyed alien. A young man approached me from within crowd and introduced himself as Abraham. Unlike the other villagers, he didn't stare at me in bewilderment. Impressively, he spoke high-level English, and he used his hands actively to point out the high school, basketball courts, and soccer field just over the hill from our house. Smiling with confidence, he shook my hand and said, "Welcome to Rwanda!"

Well, at least we had Abraham.

Aristide had warned me about the "paparazzi." A sophomore mechanical engineer and one of the few Rwandan students at Duke, Aristide had offered to teach me about Rwandan culture. "First of all," he said laughing, "everybody in the village will stare at you. They will follow you everywhere. Many have never seen a white person before." We rocked back and forth on the swinging benches outside Pitchforks Café. "Second, be prepared for a lot of gossip. If there's one thing Rwandans are good at, it's gossiping behind your back." He folded his arms against his chest. "And since you're a guy, get ready to be swarmed by girls. It's a bit weird, but in the village it's common for girls to hug you and hold your hands the whole time they talk to you. Just giving you fair warning." Enthusiastically, Aristide explained key Kinyarwanda phrases for me to know by heart, especially "*Si mbizi*" – *I'm confused*, and "*Iki bacyita mu Kinyarwanda*" – *What is this in Kinyarwanda?*

I couldn't go anywhere without a swarm at my heels, yet strangely nobody in the village knew who Adam was, where New Jersey was, what Duke University was - my past history meant nothing. I had lost all connections: roads, address-books, phone

numbers, computers, Internet. I floated isolated in the middle of a foreign continent, with only a thirty-six page Kinyarwanda to English dictionary for assistance. My transformation began with a ground-zero demolition. I became a formless ball of clay to be molded.

After my identity cleansing, I began the long process of adaptation. For Americans especially, adaptation is an ancient biological skill seldom required. Americans expect immigrants and newcomers to adapt to them. “Don’t know English? Learn it.” “Not used to the city life? Get used to it.” “Lost in the subway station? Get a map.” As a newcomer, I dug deep into my human roots and began assimilating to my Rwandan environment. The first step was primarily physical...and painful.

Jagged edges dug into my neck as I hoisted the rocks from the drop-off to the bridge site. I felt the weight bearing down into my joints with every step, and I began to take breaks more frequently to catch my breath. Sometimes, I needed to switch the rock from right to left midway through the carry to prevent my shoulder from falling off. Tossing the rocks into the pile left my skin reddened and scratched. By midday, intense sunlight shimmered on the tin-roofed homes that speckled the terraced mountainsides. Wiping beads of sweat from my brow, I headed back to carry more rocks...over and over and over again.

When I walked down the path hoisting a considerable rock, Mike, our media manager, would wink and note, “Nice one. I’d give that a seven out of ten.” From the start, Mike’s loud, outgoing, and - until you got to know him - somewhat obnoxious personality brought contagious energy to the worksite and house. While we worked, we

joked that if Mike were an inanimate object, he would be *Axe Body Spray*. Eventually, rocks became a measurement of time. Halfway through the day, I would stop and ask our safety manager, Jocelyn, “Are we breaking for lunch yet?” Technically, Jocelyn had just completed her freshman year of college, but to us, she was “Grandma.” At any moment of the day, she could be found cross-legged on the ground or perched on a rock, sneaking open her book to read.

Squinting back the sun, she’d respond, “Not yet...after four more rocks.”

Every time the dump truck sputtered and coughed down to the drop-off area, my teammates and I groaned in collective exasperation. The yellow lights flashed, the siren sounded, and a fresh new batch came thundering down in a cloud of dust. Some nights, I would wake up cold with sweat, panting under my mosquito net because I thought I heard the dump truck sputtering to make yet another delivery.

One morning, however, I woke up at 4:00 a.m. and hiked up the mountain overlooking the bridge site to see the sunrise. When I reached the peak, I looked down, exhilarated. Below in the darkness, impenetrable clouds buried all of Kiruli. Faintly, I could hear the engine of a single motorcycle humming in the distance and only guess at where the muddy soccer field might’ve been. Above, mountains watched over solemnly and unmoved, their peaks cloaked in mist. Inside their homes, villagers awakened to rooster calls and the groans of cows. Flint sparks ignited blue-hot flames beneath small stoves, beans swelled and boiled in saucepans, and the bottoms of rice pots began to sizzle. Gently, I opened my journal. Pages tattered and browned, it archived my memory: the good, the bad – everything. Tuning my senses, I tried to describe the world stirring around me:

Sights... White wildflowers are delicate snowflakes. String pea pods hang from wooden posts. Stone piles separate gardens. Low-lying ivy creeps over the stones. Stalks of brown wheat sway with wind. Kernels drift away, carried like feathers. A house. Morning warms cobblestone roof shillings. Sounds... Inside the house, children begin speaking Kinyarwanda. Mother cracks eggs on sizzling skillet. More birds chime in. Smells... ozone electrifies my focus. Fresh air revitalizes my mind. Ripe bananas, sweet nectar. Textures... Shadows melt away, revealing broad tree leaves. Terraces traverse and cut the mountainsides. Rectangular farm patches form a quilt pattern. Rough stone. Dew-covered grass...

I couldn't write quickly enough. There were too many sights to take in, too many gears moving at once. I put down my pen. Pink sky intensified into orange. Orange softened into gold. As the sky warmed brighter, the mountains darkened. Sitting back, I let the sunrise take its course, and watched the glow cloak the clouded forest below. *I Million Killed in 100 Days*. While reading about the Genocide, I had learned hundreds of thousands of bodies still laid undiscovered in the marshes and forests. Hiking down through the quiet eucalyptus forest, I watched my footing, stepping carefully around branches and rubble – I shivered at the thought of uncovering bones, disturbing someone I wasn't supposed to. Instead, sleepy morning light filtered through the leaves like stained glass and glistened in the mist as I returned home and prepared for another day of work.

The bridge construction progressed rapidly. We completed excavation in a matter of days, filled the foundations completely with rocks, and began raising the tiers. While we mixed mortar for building the walls of the tiers, I traded English and Kinyarwanda

with Nzeyimana and taught him to sing, “Head, Shoulders, Knees, and Toes.” His grin was contagious and illuminated his face under his floppy sunhat as he pointed to his head, shoulders, knees, and toes and pronounced the words in English. He doubled over in laughter when I asked if he could sing it backwards. Nzeyimana could have been a Hollywood star in an alternate universe – I imagined him rolling up in a limousine, stepping out to flashing cameras, clad in tuxedo and sunglasses. He reminded me of someone who had thought of something funny and couldn’t suppress a smile – this was Nzeyimana all the time. Every morning, he arrived to the worksite smiling and cheerful, greeting everyone on the Duke team warmly by name. When we shook hands, he would raise his eyebrows and whisper gleefully, “Adam! Last night, Nzeyimana and girlfriend *jigga-jigga* too much.” He grimaced jokingly and rubbed his sore back. “Work today...bigger, bigger problem.” It didn’t take me long to figure out what *jigga-jigga* meant, and then I realized why Nzeyimana was always so happy.

A few days later, as I handed rocks from the pile up to the masons working on the tiers, Aisha left her spot mixing concrete and approached me. “Adam, give me sweatshirt,” she said. I shrugged and handed her the grey Nike pullover I brought to work every day. *Why did she need my sweatshirt?* When Aisha returned, she handed me back the sweatshirt. She had twisted it into a pad and tied it off with a spiral of twine. Smiling, she demonstrated how I should place the pad on my head and use it to carry rocks that way. I swelled with appreciation. “*Urakoze chane, Aisha!*” I said, shaking her hand. “Thank you very much!”

Aisha’s sweatshirt head pad changed everything. I marveled at how it dispersed weight and cushioned my head from the sharp edges. Instead of the rock pressing

unevenly on one shoulder or the other, now it rested centrally on my head, its weight dissipating throughout my body – a much more effective technique. As I reveled in my newfound rock-carrying tool, Nzeyimana flashed a smile, puffed out his chest, and put his hands on his hips with pride. “Adam, *head!*” He gave a thumbs-up, using his new English vocabulary. “Head very good!”

One day, under the harsh sun, Nzeyimana wiped beads of sweat from his forehead after we finished shoveling another pile of mortar. “Adam,” he said, looking up at me. “I go to America?” I leaned on my shovel, exhausted. “I go to America one day?” he repeated sincerely. “How much to go airplane to America?” Nzeyimana smiled and waited for my answer. I calculated the price of a plane ticket. A pit formed in my throat. Nzeyimana would have to shovel wet mortar in the searing heat for five more years to purchase but one ticket to America. I didn’t have the heart to tell him - he would never, under any circumstances, set foot in America.

Despite the outwardly friendly atmosphere at the worksite, muted feelings of strain lurked under the surface. I found myself scanning the faces of the Rwandan construction workers while I carried rocks or mixed concrete, peering into their eyes, wondering what they concealed. *1 million killed in 100 days*. By sheer statistics, everyone had a story, yet nobody said a word. Observing Jamvier, I noticed a deep scar crossing the top of his forehead – he had been using the wool beanie to hide it. I recalled how my conversation with Aristide had quelled to awkward silence.

“What about the Genocide?” I had asked hesitantly.

Until then, neither of us had brought up the topic, but I could tell, by the look on his face, that Aristide had known the question was inevitable. His bright smile faded. Sinking back against the bench, he sighed. “Even today, it’s a very complex issue for Rwandans. People still have history and memories from twenty years ago, and a lot of the emotions haven’t gone away.” He looked directly into my eyes. “If I were you, I wouldn’t bring up the Genocide.”

During the afternoons, children rushed down from the hill and along the tea fields to visit the Duke team at the construction site and see our progress. As the workday winded down, the children’s presence always resulted in my distraction – especially when they brought gifts.

“So I just...bite it?”

They nodded as I examined the stalk of wood in my hand. It reminded me of a sectioned bamboo shoot except its bark was a deep purplish brown instead of tan. Inside, the consistency reminded me of celery, in that water could move up and down through the tissue. Tentatively, I stuck the narrow end in my mouth and clamped down with my molars. I ripped the wood away in juicy shreds. Sugary drool dripped down my chin, and the kids folded over in laughter. I grinned a mouthful of sugarcane.

“This stuff isn’t half-bad,” I said between chews. Jokingly, I offered the rest to the kids. “Want some?”

Out of all the children, Madina was the craziest: a Tasmanian Devil trapped in the body of a two-year-old. Originally, I met the toddler on my very first walk to work when she ran screeching out of her house at 7:00 a.m. “*Abazungu!*” “*Abazungu!*” “*Abazungu!*”

Projectile snot flew from her nose as she shrieked and smiled. She reached out for my hand, and I shivered at its slimy moistness. She greeted me every day, some days without pants, other days completely naked. When I walked home from work, she ran up to hug me and screamed in delight as I lifted her into the air. Some days, she visited me at the construction site and fell asleep in my lap, her bobbing, fuzzy head plopping against my chest. Other days, she stole my prescription sunglasses and spun around in circles, enraptured by the distorted world, until her legs gave out and she plunked onto the ground.

After work, life centered around “The Frat House.” All ten members of the Duke team slept in the same house, occupying each of the five bedrooms as roommate pairs. Each cramped bedroom was fitted with one dim light bulb, two mosquito nets, and two mattresses. The shared outhouse was located across the broken cobblestone courtyard. Empty pink cups and glass bottles of Fanta lay in disarray on the plastic chairs, crumpled pieces of bridge design clustered in the corners, and a single crudely drawn stick-figure portrait of Catherine and Tim surrounded by hearts hung as a “decoration.” On a daily basis, bits and pieces of cement crumbled from the walls, and despite our best efforts, mud always found its way into our barren living room; however, come dinnertime, music, laughter, visitors, and conversation brought our dimly lit home to life, and clearly, the loudest voice belonged to Abraham.

For Abraham, talking was exhilarating. Formulating every word, he delivered his message like it was the most important article of information one could ever know. He joined us for dinner often and always sat next to me, tucking his feet under his chair and hugging his black backpack on his lap. Even when speaking about common topics like

clothing, he paid meticulous attention to detail - I imagined a bomb-squad specialist explaining which wire to cut.

“Adam, do you see these clothes I am wearing?” I looked at his clothes and braced myself for another elaborate story. “These clothes are somehow sufficient for living in Base, but, for example, when I go to university in Kigali in October, these clothes will not be good.” Abraham has two outfits: navy athletic pants and a black Adidas shirt for the weekdays and a business casual blue button-down and black khakis for Sunday Mass. “You see, when I was in primary school and high school, we all were given uniforms by the government, so nobody knew what kinds of clothes I wore.” Laughing, he continued, “But now, when I go to university, everyone will see my clothes and think *‘Oh, this guy is definitely from the village.’*”

Every Sunday, Abraham and I walked two miles from Kiruli to Cyohoha for Catholic Mass. After each reading he whispered, sometimes too closely, in my ear, translating from Kinyarwanda to English: “The priest is telling the story of Pentecost” or “He is reading Paul’s letter to the Corinthians.” Abraham also proved Aristide correct and gave me valuable insight into Rwandan gossip that I surely wouldn’t have known otherwise. “Adam, do you know how priests are not supposed to have children?” His voice bubbled with excitement as he pointed to the priest speaking into the microphone. “There are rumors this priest has many children secretly in the village - he is not a very good priest!”

As the tiers rose higher and higher toward completion, clangs of hammers pierced the air constantly as the masons chiseled away at the rocks to sculpt them into desired

shapes. Chips and pieces exploded with each strike. I watched in awe as the experts ran their fingers along the rocks' surfaces, tapping and feeling for weaknesses in the layers, like detectives searching for a fingerprint. A few delicate taps with the hammer and one violent blow would slice the rocks into two even slabs. They even gathered the broken fragments and used them to fill the gaps in tiers.

I loved watching Damascene, especially. The stocky head boss was built like a fire hydrant and always seemed to be measuring something with complete focus. He set the tone at the construction site. Whenever his workers goofed off or got distracted, he simply had to look their way and they would grab the nearest shovel and get back to work immediately. One time, water began pooling in the bottom of the right anchor trench, and Damascene invented one of the most ingenious solutions I've ever seen.

We needed to keep the trench dry because soon we were set to fill it with concrete during cable setting. Damascene grabbed a broad banana leaf, cross-section of banana trunk, and machete and climbed down into the two-and-a-half meter trench. He sliced the trunk cross-section into a concave semi-oval and wrapped it in the leaf. Then, with the tip of the machete, he carved a small hole in the clay where the water was trickling. Gently, he pressed the cross-section and leaf into the hole and molded it into the wall with his hands. Crystal water trickled through the cross-section and streamed from the tip of the banana leaf. Then, Damascene washed his hands in his makeshift "tap," filled up his water bottle, and placed a Jerry Can underneath to collect the water. Everybody who had been peering down in amazement scrambled back to work.

After finishing the third tiers on both embankments, we moved into the approach wall phase. The system of carrying rocks remained the same, except since the top of the third tier was three meters tall, we had to lift the rocks high over our heads and give them to the masons. We turned this lifting into a type of game. I brought my speakers to the worksite and blasted Don McLean and Billy Joel. Mike and Nzeyimana danced and tapped their feet while handing the rocks up to the masons. Even Damascene smiled and busted out a couple of smooth moves.

Connor tapped me on the shoulder. “Dude, check out this rock.” I turned to see what he was talking about. He held a smooth, rectangular rock about two feet in length with even dimensions. “Good weight, solid grip, perfect size.” He handed me the rock. I ran my hand along its smooth edges and turned it upside-down to check its balance. “We should bring this back to the house and use it for shoulder and bench press,” said Connor. “I bet we could find a couple more for curls, too.”

Genius. That afternoon, I carried a rock in a completely different direction on a completely different path: past tea fields, homes, and David’s teashop, past the muddy soccer field, cow pastures, and primary school. Instead of sprinting down the hill to hug me like usual, the schoolchildren scratched their heads in confusion. *Where is he going, and why is he carrying a rock on his head?* I ended up carrying the roughly forty pound rock on my head all the way from the worksite to the doorstep of my house – over half a mile.

During the afternoons after work, there was nothing to do *besides* exercise. I created a playlist of Eminem, Avicii, and White Panda on my iPod. Connor moved the plastic chairs and benches to the perimeter of the living room, while Mike brought out his

Crazy Creek to use as a floor-mat for push-ups and planks. Plugging in my speakers, I ignited my playlist and let the music blast into the courtyard. Mike tore off his shirt immediately and began doing pull-ups on the low wooden crossbeams that spanned the ceiling of our house. Connor carried the rocks into the house and set them on the floor. On that fateful day, “Rock Gym” was born.

Many days after work, Nzeyimana, Jamvier, and the rest of the Rwandan construction workers joined us in our house for Rock Gym. Abraham walked over from Base, too. We used our rocks as free-weights for shoulder presses, curls, and benching, passing them around so everyone got a chance. During the workouts we went so hard and got so fired up that one time Jocelyn couldn’t handle the racket and had to leave and read “Little Women” in the kitchen.

After workouts, we all gathered around Connor’s laptop and watched Go-Pro time-lapse footage of the bridge construction. The first shots of the undeveloped site seemed alien in retrospect. Tea fields grew over the foundation, and there was not a single rock in sight. Now, two colossal stone tiers towered over the valley. Nzeyimana beamed and pointed at himself mixing concrete on the screen. Jamvier failed to suppress his laughter when he walked up to the GoPro and put his eye directly into the lens. Abraham even translated for Nzeyimana and Jamvier, allowing them to speak sincerely to the whole Duke team - they told us how thankful they were for us to join their community, that they loved us.

The bridge lost its importance in a good way – it was just the answer I gave to people when they asked “Why are you in Rwanda?” When I wrote in my journal, I smiled to myself, laughing quietly at Abraham’s hilarious sayings and moments:

Adam, last night at the party when I was drinking the jungle juice, some of the workers did not know it contains alcohol because it is somehow so sweet. They kept asking me for more, and I thought this was so funny because they are Protestant! In Rwanda, Protestants can be excommunicated for drinking alcohol!

Days blurred together. At night, I stayed up late and talked to my team about Jack Johnson, Game of Thrones, and the NBA Finals. I learned the lyrics and accompanying dance moves to Rwandan songs like “Amarulah” and “Till I Die.” I grinned and nudged Abraham in the ribs when he texted his girlfriend in Kigali discreetly. When he asked me if I had a girlfriend, I slunk into my plastic chair...*Touché*.

I all but forgot about my friends at home. Weeks passed without calling my parents. Occasionally while mixing concrete, I stopped and remembered the place I came from. I had two lives and only enough hours in the day for one. Eventually, I stopped journaling altogether because the act of remembering foreshadowed my inevitable leaving Rwanda. Over time, however, I found myself biting my lip with guilt. No amount of carrying rocks or mixing concrete could give my Rwandan friends and workers the same opportunities I had. A few weeks of manual labor for me could never compare to a lifetime for them. Without a cell-phone, computer, or running water, I was happier than I’d ever been in my life, but deep down, I knew this wasn’t my reality and soon I’d have

to wake up. *We would complete the bridge. I would leave. They would stay. Life would go on.*

No pictures decorated the empty cement walls of Abraham's house. I sat in one wooden chair; my friend sat in the other. From across the small table, he offered me a cup of *uragwa*, a sour drink made of fermented bananas. He sipped from his own cup, glaring into the swirling, brown liquid. Biting his lip in dissatisfaction, he placed the cup on the table. In the adjacent bedroom, his mother, brother, and sister slept. For all nineteen years of his life, Abraham called this space "home." Facing me, his eyes burned dark with certainty, not a sliver of doubt in his voice:

"When I was seven, I analyzed my situation, and I concluded my future was in my own hands," he said.

"I refuse to grow old in Africa."

Under the lonely night sky, we walked the uneven dirt path back to my home in Kiruli. He never needed a flashlight – he'd walked the path in weathered flip-flops thousands of times. "I was born in Exile in the Congo, and my father died while I was still a baby. Two years after the Genocide, there were still wars in the country. The government was very corrupt, and living in Rwanda was very dangerous." Even in the darkness, I could feel his voice lift. "But now, things have changed, and Rwanda is somehow the fastest developing country in all of Africa. There are no longer Hutu or Tutsi. There are no longer tribes. We are all simply Rwandan."

Abraham's mother returned to Rwanda to raise him and his siblings and rebuild their lives from nothing. "When my mum saw I was excelling in school, she took a risk and bought a radio so that I may learn English," said Abraham. "I didn't have the proper equipment like pencils and notebooks, so I listened to music mixes on Voice of America. I learned all of the popular American artists like Chris Brown, Usher, and Taylor Swift. I memorized the lyrics and practiced the words by myself."

"Why were you so determined to learn English?" I asked.

He put his hands in the pockets of his worn-out pants. "In Rwanda, all chemistry, mathematics, physics, and biology are taught in English, not Kinyarwanda. If you don't learn English, you can't learn anything."

Abraham explained that poverty was always an obstacle for him and his family. When his mother couldn't pay the school fees, he went to class secretly and listened from outside the iron-barred windows. "Sometimes the teacher chased me out of the school with a stick," he said with a chuckle. "But, I kept going to school because I had to learn English to pass the National Exam. If I scored high enough, I could receive an interview to study in America."

"One week before the National Exam, I became very sick with malaria."

Optimism and confidence faded and left his voice hollowed. "I even did my exams in the hospital." The memory still plagues Abraham. Often, he stares bitterly out into empty space, and I know exactly what moment he is reliving. "I received an 83.5% while I required at least 90% to perform the interview. At that moment, my dreams stopped." Moonlight cracked through the trees on the mountainside, and Abraham's spirits lifted

again. “Even though I missed that chance, I realized I had nothing to lose and that I would always keep trying my best. After all, I will never attain my dreams if I don’t at least try.”

The opportunities I was born with: Abraham’s life revolved around attaining *chances* to even scratch at the surface of these opportunities. Tea fields sprawled far in the distance under the clear, gray sky, as we walked past the padlocked bakeries and bars of Kiruli. Faintly, I could discern my house in the darkness. Quietly, we opened the steel gate to the courtyard and stopped outside my front door. Abraham stroked his beard in deep thought. “Adam, I think the best chance I ever got was meeting you and the rest of the Duke team. You are the first Americans I’ve met, and I thought I wanted to observe your behaviors and somehow ask you questions about the United States.” He looked into my eyes as he said this, and I recalled the first time I ever met Abraham, the way he listened and absorbed everything he saw. During any conversation, his entire being focused completely, his eyes flickering back and forth as he translated from English to Kinyarwanda in his mind.

“I think you’ll make it to America, Abraham,” I said.

“I know I will,” he said without hesitation. “Because I have met you, I have so much hope. Even though it is very hard for me to go to the United States, I am confident I will achieve my dreams,” said Abraham. “I think I will do it mostly with my own hard work and with prayers.” He forced a smile. “I just hope I get there before I’m fifty-five years old.”

At the Bridge Inauguration, the Kiruli community gathered under the shade of the eucalyptus forest. I sat beside Abraham in the soft grass. Babies like Madina gurgled in their mothers' laps. The workers beamed, wearing their finest collared shirts. The bridge had come a long way from a dusty pile of rocks. During the seventh week, the steel cables arrived at the worksite, and we set the sag, nailed the wooden decking into place, and attached the safety fencing. Under glowing orange sunset, we helped the children paint the towers blue, yellow, and green – the colors of the Rwandan flag.

The ceremony was simple. The Mayor of the Rulindo District spoke and called up Jamvier, naming him to the bridge maintenance council. The dedicated construction worker glowed upon receiving his leadership position. Turning, he addressed the community in Kinyarwanda. As always, Abraham whispered the translation in my ear: “We have seen how this bridge is built, we understand it, and we have learned so much. We will protect it because it is ours.” Brooke, the Bridges to Prosperity manager, spoke, emphasizing how the bridge would last the village for generations and generations. Finally, Connor delivered a short but beautiful speech, thanking Kiruli for accepting the Duke team into their families and community.

Delicate leaves spiraled like pinwheels in the warm breeze and fell gently into the crowd. Nzeyimana flashed his smile, and when we made eye contact, he nodded and gave a thumbs-up. My eyes softened – everyone I'd come to love had joined together to celebrate the bridge. I scanned the familiar faces of the villagers, women, men, and children, young and old. Then, I froze.

At first, I didn't think the brutally disfigured face could be human. My spine locked rigidly in place. I couldn't look away. A woman, at least I think it was a woman, wearing a yellow collared shirt sat in the crowd. A gruesome scar split her face vertically, and burns left her skin mottled and blotchy. Where her nose was supposed to be, there were but two uneven, thin slits. What were left of her eyes were fleshy, beady holes. Her upper lip had been cut off, revealing a jagged row of teeth. Both of her hands had been chopped off and scarred over into knobs.

In her lap, a baby giggled with laughter. She played with the baby gently, and from a distance I saw her smile. Surrounded by friends and family, she was at peace, filled with joy. I couldn't imagine how such horrific violence could have existed in such a beautiful place. She was an unfortunate, innocent, helpless, victim – a genocide survivor. *That could've been Nzeyimana, Jamvier, or Damascene. Even Madina.*

It could've been Abraham.

All of the *people*, the promising *individuals* lost in the Genocide, I couldn't wrap my mind around it. Surrounded by the leaves falling like pinwheels, I held my head in my hands and prayed for all of the mothers, fathers, sons, and daughters whose lives were cut too short. I thanked God for Kiruli and the lives spared.

The crowd danced traditional dances, chanted, and filled the eucalyptus forest with their laughter. I never saw the Genocide victim again. Children darted down from the grassy terraces and dodged between the trees. To inaugurate the bridge officially, the community crossed together for the first time. Watching in the distance, I was amazed

when the crowd parted to let the first person cross. An old, blind man trembled as he took timid first steps. Children took his hands gently and led him up the approach ramps. At the top, his cheeks turned up into a wrinkled smile as he took hold of the steel cables. The Kiruli community cheered as his steps gained confidence.



